CHAPTER TWENTY-SEVEN

A CHOICE GONE WRONG

Mismatched Expectations

When Cyrus Mistry took over from Ratan, not many expected him to take the group to greater heights and gain more international recognition. The most hopeful view was that he would manage to come to grips with the complexities of the task after perhaps going through a longer learning curve than his predecessors. But after nearly four years, the overwhelming opinion was that Mistry was unable to rise to the occasion in his performance as chairman.

Mistry started with many handicaps as compared to his predecessors. Before their appointment to the top post, all the former chairmen had occupied crucial positions in the group companies, taking decisions in various capacities. Most importantly, they had predominantly worked in Tata companies. Sir Dorabji and Sir Saklatvala, for example, had spent twenty-two and twenty years respectively with the group before they adorned the mantle. Even JRD, who rose to the helm after Saklatvala's sudden demise, had spent thirteen years in the group and had also started the aviation department in the Tatas before becoming chairman. This made the chairmen familiar with the functioning, overarching cultural ethos and vision of the conglomerate.

In contrast, before being appointed as chairman, Mistry had not held any executive post. He was only a non-executive director in the Tata Sons board for around six years and prior to that, a director with Tata Power. These roles gave him some insight into the functioning of the group, but they were no substitute for the valuable experience that can be gained by working at the operational level. Neither did he have any experience as the head of any